



Grandfathered In

Renewal of Horizon-Scan Recommendations After Their Founding Signal Lapses

Ingrid Vasseur · Verity Marris — School of Emergent Priorities

The problem

Horizon-scan recommendations are meant to lapse when the signal that justified them does. Little is known about what happens once a recommendation's founding condition has expired but its funding line has not.

Research questions

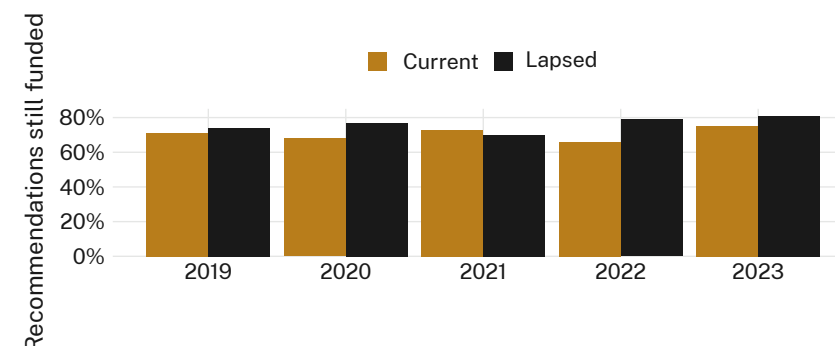
- Are justification-lapsed recommendations retired faster than still-current ones?
- How long between signal lapse and funding review, where review occurs at all?
- Do renewal outcomes track cohort of origin more than present relevance?

Study design

- n = 86 Trajectory Analytics Group recommendations · 5 annual scan cohorts (2019–2023)
- each coded against its own signal's five-year sunset window; renewal tracked across three Strategic Drift Survey cycles
- sunset coding fixed before funding outcomes were consulted; no post-hoc threshold adjustment

Findings

Recommendations coded justification-lapsed were renewed at rates matching or exceeding still-current recommendations in four of the five cohorts studied.



Across the 2019–2023 cohorts, lapsed-justification recommendations averaged a 76% renewal rate at their next Strategic Drift Survey review, against 71% for still-current recommendations.

Interpretation & conclusions

A recommendation's continued funding tracks its cohort of origin more than its present relevance. Renewal panels report reviewing "the recommendation," not the signal beneath it. Next: extending the audit to the Adaptive Metrics Lab's own indicator retirements.

Selected references

1. Pierson, P. (2000). Increasing returns, path dependence, and the study of politics. *American Political Science Review*, 94(2), 251–267. doi:10.2307/2586011
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3. Geva-May, I. (2004). Riding the wave of opportunity: Termination in public policy. *Journal of Public Administration Research and Theory*, 14(3), 309–333. doi:10.1093/jopart/muh022
4. Cohen, M. D., March, J. G., & Olsen, J. P. (1972). A garbage can model of organizational choice. *Administrative Science Quarterly*, 17(1), 1–25. doi:10.2307/2392088
5. Hogwood, B. W., & Peters, B. G. (1982). The dynamics of policy change: Policy succession. *Policy Sciences*, 14(3), 225–245. doi:10.1007/BF00136400

Retrospective record audit only; no committee members interviewed; sunset coding fixed before funding outcomes were consulted.

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"The signal expired in 2021. The funding didn't notice."

76% of lapsed-justification recommendations were renewed at their next review, 2019–2023.